

retirement years, realizing the nest egg they *thought* would support them simply can't. And so they keep working, depend on Social Security, and pray they stay healthy.

Even if they do stay relatively healthy, though, Medicare premiums alone can wreck their finances. CNN Money reports that the typical healthy, sixty-five-year-old couple can expect to spend \$266,600 on Medicare premiums alone throughout their retirement years, and that doesn't even include out-of-pocket expenses or long-term care costs.³⁸ So, if the average person that age has \$209,984 in their 401(k) and he can expect to spend \$266,600 on premiums alone for himself and his spouse, you can see the train wreck happening in slow motion. If they don't find some other source of income, they'll be moving in with their kids or falling for some trashy reverse-mortgage sales pitch. Don't let that be your plan for retirement.

I know that saving for the long term can seem overwhelming, especially with the immediate needs of the present. But the kinds of financial limitations mentioned above don't just hurt your future retirement; they hurt how well you can live your life in the here and now. Financial independence brings flexibility, margin, options, and availability—but you don't have those things when you're living a life stuck in debt and out-of-control spending. For example, many years ago our family heard about another family in our church who had lost everything in a fire. Our hearts broke for them, and we wanted to do something huge to help them. But when we really thought it through, we couldn't. We couldn't afford to help them—not as much as we wanted to, anyway. We were still in debt at the time, and we were working our tails off to clean up the mess we had made for ourselves. In choosing to obligate myself to Visa, I had chosen *not* to be available to help other people when they really needed it. It felt like I was in financial handcuffs, and it added even more fuel to my fire to get my act together. Maybe you know what that feels like. When faced with that lack of freedom, you can either give up and stay there forever or can get mad and change your situation. Too many people give up. Millionaire-minded people don't.

If you're determined to hit the millionaire mark, start thinking about what you will do with the freedom that comes with financial independence. Don't just daydream about it; write down specific things you want to do. What